with condition that unless a political agreement comes about, they are not going to go out?[67]

Other Congress members such as V. B. Raju and Dinesh Singh (who was also a former EAM in 1969–70, and took the same office again during 1993–95) joined the growing criticism against Gandhi's pro-Soviet tilt.[68] Top Janata Party leaders such as Morarji Desai and Jagjivan Ram had made their anti-Congress stance clear from the outset.[69] Syed Shahabuddin, a Janata Party MP, said that 'the Russian action and our reaction thereto cannot but revive the memories of Hungary and Czechoslovakia and the ambitious and ambivalent attitude adopted then.'[70] Advocating caution in dealing with the situation, another opposition leader, Madhu Dandavate, wittily argued that India's nonalignment had to be 'genuine' and not 'tilted like the leaning tower of Pisa.'[71] For all these parties, the government should have known better than to buy Soviet theories of entering Afghanistan on Kabul's request, so as to contain 'counter-revolutionary' forces.

In September 1980, Vajpayee, who had previously (as EAM) welcomed the change of guard in Kabul in 1978, asked if the bonds of Indo-Soviet friendship are so fragile as to be shattered merely by calling a spade a spade.'[72] It was 'highly regrettable that instead of raising a powerful protest against the Soviet interference in the affairs of Afghanistan, our traditional friend and non-aligned neighbour, the attitude adopted by Mrs. Gandhi's Government on this issue right from the beginning has resulted in lowering of our prestige in the eyes of the world, reducing our credibility among non-aligned nations and isolating us from our neighbours', countered Vajpayee.[73]

BJP General Secretary, Sikander Bakht, who started his political career with the Congress then shifted to the Janata Party and finally ended up with the BJP, added that the Soviet Union was a 'modern colonial power' whose 'next victim could be Baluchistan', in which case India's borders would be threatened directly.[74] Some opposition politicians even demanded the revocation of the 1971 Indo-Soviet friendship treaty on the grounds that Moscow displayed a tendency to use friendship treaties in order to interfere in the domestic politics of other countries.[75] In April 1981, during a visit to the US, Subramanian Swamy, a Janata Party leader (who later became a staunch Hindu nationalist), argued that the Gandhi government's 'needlessly close relations' with Moscow alienated India in South Asia and elsewhere. He wondered why India should 'pay such a heavy